How to Present Your Research

Conference Presentation Guide

A Thesis Guide

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Abstract

A research presentation is not a thesis read aloud. It is a different kind of communication with a different purpose: in fifteen or twenty minutes, a speaker must make an audience understand a problem, believe that the question matters, follow the method, remember one or two findings, and see why those findings deserve attention. This guide explains how to do that. It covers the purpose of a conference presentation, how to know and respect an audience, how to structure a talk around problem, question, method, findings and contribution, how to design slides that support rather than replace the speaker, how to make data visuals that an audience can read in seconds, and how to speak with pace, clarity and confidence.

The guide also covers the parts of presenting that students worry about most: handling questions from the audience, including difficult and critical ones; preparing poster presentations; presenting online and in virtual conferences; managing timing through rehearsal; and avoiding the common mistakes that weaken even strong research. Each chapter includes practical checklists and worked examples, including a complete outline of a fictional talk that students can adapt to their own work. The examples are clearly labelled as fictional and invent no real study, person or conference.

The advice in this guide is written for undergraduate and postgraduate students presenting for the first time, as well as for early-career researchers who want to improve. It assumes no prior presenting experience and no expensive equipment: a laptop, a projector, a clear structure and honest rehearsal are enough. The central message is simple. A good presentation is not a performance and it is not a test of memory. It is a conversation with an audience that has given you its time. Respect that time, say one clear thing well, and invite the audience to respond.

Keywords: research presentation, conference talk, academic speaking, slide design, poster presentation, questions and answers, rehearsal

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 to 3 before you plan any talk, because purpose, audience and structure decide everything else. Use Chapters 4 and 5 while you build your slides, Chapter 6 while you practise speaking, and Chapters 7 to 10 for questions, posters, online talks and rehearsal. Chapter 12 gives a full worked outline to adapt. Chapter 11 is your final check before the day of the talk.

Chapter 1: Purpose of a Research Presentation

Many first-time presenters make the same mistake: they try to fit their whole thesis into twenty minutes. They open with a long history of the topic, read dense paragraphs from their slides, rush through the findings, and run out of time before the conclusion. The audience leaves remembering nothing except that the speaker spoke quickly. The mistake is understandable, because the presenter cares about the research and wants to show all of it. But a presentation is not a smaller thesis. It is a different task with a different purpose, and it succeeds by different rules.

The purpose of a research presentation is to make an audience understand and remember one clear message. A thesis proves a claim in detail over many pages, with every piece of evidence laid out for a reader who can pause, re-read and check. A presentation must work in real time, for listeners who cannot rewind. If the audience leaves with one finding, one reason it matters, and one question they want to ask, the talk has succeeded. If they leave with a blur of slides and no clear message, it has not, however much work went into it.

1.1 What a presentation can do that a paper cannot

A paper is read alone, in silence, at the reader's own pace. A presentation happens in a room full of people, and that changes what is possible. The speaker can show enthusiasm, point to the important part of a graph, pause for effect, watch the audience's faces and adjust. The audience can ask questions at once, challenge an interpretation, suggest a new idea, or offer a collaboration. A good presentation therefore does more than report results: it starts a conversation. Many research collaborations, invitations and useful criticisms begin with a question asked after a talk, not with a paper read in a library.

1.2 The one-message rule

Before you build a single slide, write down your talk in one sentence. The sentence should name the problem, the finding and the significance: for example, 'Weekly peer feedback improved the writing accuracy of intermediate learners more than teacher feedback alone, which suggests that structured peer discussion helps learners notice their own errors.' If you cannot write that sentence, you are not ready to build slides. You do not yet know what your talk is about, and no amount of design will fix that.

Worked Example: Finding the one message

A student studied reading habits in three schools, collecting data on time spent reading, types of books, teacher practices and home support. Her first draft tried to report all four topics in fifteen minutes. Her one-message sentence became: 'Students read more when teachers give ten minutes of free reading time each day, and the effect is strongest for students with few books at home.' That sentence decided the structure: one slide on the problem, one on the method, one graph on the main finding, one on the home-books difference, and one on what it means. Everything else stayed in the paper.

1.3 What the audience expects from you

[ ] I can state the one message of my talk in a single sentence.

[ ] I know what I want the audience to remember the next day.

[ ] I know what I want the audience to ask me about.

[ ] Every slide I plan supports the one message.

Chapter 2: Knowing Your Audience

A talk that works for one audience can fail for another, even when the research is the same. A room of specialists wants method and detail. A room of students from other subjects wants the big idea and plain language. A mixed conference audience wants both: the idea first, the detail available for those who ask. The first job of a presenter is therefore not to open the slide software. It is to ask who will be listening, what they already know, and what they care about. The answers decide the language, the depth, the examples and the pace of the talk.

2.1 Finding out who will be there

Before the conference, read the programme. Note the title of your session, the other

speakers in it, and the kind of people who usually attend the conference. Is it a specialist conference in one field, or a general conference with many subjects? Are the other talks narrow and technical, or broad and practical? Ask your supervisor or a colleague who has attended before: how large is the audience, how long are questions, and are the listeners friendly or sharply critical? If the conference publishes a list of participants, look at who works on your topic and read one of their papers. You may be answering their question.

2.2 Specialists, generalists and non-specialists

Specialists know the literature, the methods and the debates. They will judge your talk on the quality of the evidence and the originality of the claim. With them, spend less time on background and more on what is new: the method, the key result, and how it changes what was believed before. Use the field's terms, but define any term that is new or contested. Expect detailed questions, and welcome them: a detailed question means a specialist is taking your work seriously.

Audience	What they need most	What to avoid
Specialists	Method, evidence, what is new	Long background, vague claims
Generalists	Context, plain language, one example	Unexplained terms, too much detail
Non-specialists	A real problem, one clear visual	Jargon, tables of numbers
Mixed audience	Plain opening, careful middle, big idea at the end	Assuming everyone knows the field

2.3 Reading the room while you speak

Knowing your audience does not stop when you start speaking. Watch the room as you talk. If people are nodding and taking notes, your pace is right. If they are looking at their phones, you may be going too slowly or too deeply into detail; move to the next point. If they look confused, pause and restate the idea in different words, or point again to the visual. If they look surprised, you have their attention: slow down and let the point land before you move on. These small adjustments are what separate a speaker who reads a script from a speaker who communicates.

[ ] I know what kind of conference this is and who usually attends.

[ ] I have read the session programme and the other speakers' topics.

[ ] I can explain my key terms in plain words if asked.

[ ] I have a plain-language opening for listeners outside my field.

[ ] I will watch the audience and adjust my pace as I speak.

Chapter 3: Structure - Problem, Question, Method, Findings, Contribution

Every good research talk follows the same shape, whether it lasts ten minutes or forty. It opens with a problem, states a question, explains the method briefly, presents the findings, and ends with the contribution: what the findings mean and why they matter. This shape is not a rule imposed by conference organisers. It is the shape of an argument, and audiences expect it because it matches how they think. When a talk follows this shape, the audience can follow it without effort. When a talk jumps around, the audience spends its energy trying to work out where they are, instead of listening to what you found.

This chapter works through each part of the structure in order, with guidance on how much time to give each part and what belongs in it. The proportions are for a standard twenty-minute talk; for a shorter or longer talk, keep the same order and adjust the time, never the order. A talk that starts with findings and then explains the problem is confusing even if the findings are excellent, because the audience has no reason to care about them yet.

3.1 The opening: the problem in two minutes

Open with the problem, not with yourself, your university, or a long history of the field. In the first minute, the audience should know what problem you studied and why it matters. The best openings are concrete: a classroom where students struggle, a clinic where a treatment fails, a business where costs rise. One concrete image does more work than a paragraph of general statements. After the image, state the problem in one sentence, and say why it is worth studying. If the audience does not care about the problem by the end of the second minute, they will not care about the findings either.

3.2 The question and the gap

After the problem, state your research question clearly and put it on a slide by itself, in large text. The audience should be able to read it, remember it, and use it to follow the rest of the talk. Then, in two or three sentences, say what was already known and what was missing. This is the gap, and it is the reason your study exists. Do not spend long on the literature here: name the key finding or two, name the limit, and move on. The audience does not need a review of the field. They need to know why your question was still open.

Worked Example: A clear question slide

Fictional example. Problem: many secondary students leave school with weak writing skills, although writing is taught every week. Question (on its own slide): 'Does structured peer feedback improve the writing accuracy of intermediate learners over six weeks, compared with teacher feedback alone?' Gap: earlier studies showed that learners value

feedback, but none had measured whether peer feedback actually improved accuracy in a public-school classroom. The audience now knows exactly what the talk will answer.

3.3 The method: brief, honest, enough

The method section of a talk is short: two to four minutes in a twenty-minute talk. Say what you did, who took part, and how you analysed the data, in that order. Give the numbers that matter: how many participants, how long the study ran, what instrument you used. Do not describe every step of the procedure; the paper has that detail. Do say enough that the audience can judge whether the findings are trustworthy. If you used a questionnaire, say how many items it had and whether it was piloted. If you interviewed people, say how many and for how long. If you ran an experiment, say what the groups were and how they differed.

3.4 The findings: one visual per finding

The findings are the heart of the talk, and they deserve the most time: about eight minutes in a twenty-minute talk. Present one finding at a time, with one visual per finding. Say what the audience is looking at before you show the numbers: 'This graph shows the change in accuracy scores for the three groups.' Then point to the comparison that matters and say what it means, in one sentence. Then pause, and move to the next finding. Do not show a table of twenty numbers and read them all aloud. The audience cannot absorb them, and reading numbers aloud is the fastest way to lose a room.

3.5 The contribution and the close

End with the contribution: what your findings add, and what follows from them. Answer the research question directly, in one sentence, on a slide the audience can read. Then say what the finding means for practice, for policy, or for future research, in two or three short points. Do not introduce new results in the conclusion. Do not end with 'Thank you' on a blank slide while the audience is still waiting for the message; end with the message itself, then thank the audience and invite questions. The last slide should carry your conclusion and your contact details, so that the audience can photograph it or note it down while they ask questions.

[ ] My talk follows the order: problem, question, method, findings, contribution.

[ ] The question appears on its own slide in large text.

[ ] The method takes no more than a quarter of the talk.

[ ] Each finding has one visual and one sentence of meaning.

[ ] The conclusion answers the question directly and states the contribution.

Chapter 4: Designing Slides - Few Words, Large Text, One Visual per Finding

Slides are the most visible part of a presentation, and the most commonly mishandled. The commonest error is to put the talk on the slides: full paragraphs, small text, long lists, and tables copied from the thesis. The speaker then reads the slides aloud, and the audience reads them too, faster than the speaker, and stops listening. Slides should do the opposite job. They should carry what words cannot carry well: a picture, a graph, a diagram, a single key sentence. The speaker carries the words. When slides and speaker do different jobs, the talk works. When they do the same job, one of them is unnecessary, and it is usually the speaker who loses.

This chapter gives practical rules for slide design that work in any software and in any conference room: few words, large text, one idea per slide, one visual per finding, and a consistent, readable design. None of these rules requires design skill. They require only the discipline to cut words and to test every slide by asking, 'Can the person in the back row read this in five seconds?' If the answer is no, the slide needs to change.

4.1 Few words: the six-by-six guide

A useful guide is six lines per slide and six words per line, at most. It is a guide, not a law, and a slide with a short quotation or a single question may break it. But it is a good test: if your slide has more words than this, it is probably a document, not a slide. Cut it down to the words the audience needs to follow you. The rest belongs in your notes, where you can say it aloud, or in a handout, where the audience can read it later.

- Use short phrases and key words, not full paragraphs.
- Put one idea on each slide; if a slide has two ideas, split it.
- Never paste a paragraph from your thesis onto a slide.
- Use the speaker notes for what you will say; use the slide for what the audience should see.

4.2 Large text and readable design

Text on slides must be large enough to read from the back of the room. As a rule, the smallest text on a slide should be 24 points, headings should be 32 points or larger, and the title of the talk should be larger still. If you cannot fit your words at that size, you have too many words, not too small a font. Test your slides by standing at the back of a room, or by shrinking them on your screen until they are the size of a postcard: if you can still read the main words, the size is right.

4.3 One visual per finding

Each finding deserves its own slide with its own visual. The visual may be a graph, a table with few numbers, a photograph, a diagram, or a short quotation. Whatever it is, it should be large, simple and labelled clearly, with a title that states the finding,

not just the topic. A slide titled 'Results' tells the audience nothing. A slide titled 'Peer feedback improved accuracy more than teacher feedback' tells them the finding before they have even read the graph. Write slide titles as conclusions, not as labels.

Worked Example: Before and after: a crowded slide

Before: a slide titled 'Results' with a paragraph of 80 words, a table of 20 numbers in 14-point text, and a small graph in the corner. The audience reads the paragraph, ignores the graph, and stops listening. After: three slides. Slide one, titled 'Accuracy improved in all groups', shows one bar chart with three bars. Slide two, titled 'Peer feedback gained most', shows the same chart with the peer-feedback bar highlighted. Slide three, titled 'The gain lasted four weeks later', shows a simple line for the follow-up test. Each slide takes seconds to read, and the speaker has time to explain each one.

[ ] No slide has more than six lines or six words per line.

[ ] The smallest text is at least 24 points.

[ ] Each slide has one idea and a title that states a conclusion.

[ ] Each finding has its own slide with one large, simple visual.

[ ] The design is consistent: one font, strong contrast, same layout.

[ ] Every image is sharp, relevant and credited.

Chapter 5: Data Visuals That Work

Data visuals are the part of a presentation where good research most often fails to communicate. A graph that is clear in a paper, where the reader can study it for a minute, can be unreadable when it appears on a screen for thirty seconds. The rules for presentation visuals are therefore stricter than the rules for paper visuals. A presentation visual must be understood at a glance, from a distance, by people who have not seen it before. This chapter explains how to choose the right chart, how to simplify it, and how to talk about it so that the audience understands the finding, not just the picture.

The first decision is which kind of visual to use. The choice depends on what you want the audience to see. If you want them to compare amounts, use a bar chart. If you want them to see a change over time, use a line chart. If you want them to see parts of a whole, use a simple pie chart with few slices, or a stacked bar. If you want them to see a relationship between two things, use a scatter plot. If you want them to see exact numbers, use a small table. Choosing the wrong chart forces the audience to work hard for a simple message, and most of them will not bother.

5.1 Bar charts, line charts and tables

5.2 Simplifying a visual for the screen

Take every visual you plan to use and simplify it in four steps. First, remove the title from inside the chart and make it the slide title instead, written as a conclusion. Second, remove gridlines, borders and background shading. Third, remove any data series that does not support the point of the slide. Fourth, enlarge what remains:

labels, numbers and lines. A visual that survives these four steps is ready for a screen. A visual that still looks crowded after them should be split into two visuals, each making one point.

Worked Example: Simplifying a graph

Fictional example. A student first showed a line graph with six lines, a legend, gridlines and a title inside the chart, in 12-point text. Nobody in the audience could follow it. She simplified it to three lines, labelled at their ends, with no gridlines, thick lines, and the slide title 'Peer feedback gained most, and the gain lasted'. The audience understood the finding in seconds, and the questions that followed were about what the finding meant, not about how to read the graph. That is the difference a simple visual makes.

5.3 Talking about a visual

A visual does not speak for itself. The speaker must guide the audience through it in three short steps. First, say what the visual shows: 'This bar chart shows the change in accuracy scores for the three groups.' Second, point to the comparison that matters: 'Look at the middle bar. The peer-feedback group gained about 13 points.' Third, say what it means: 'That is five points more than teacher feedback, which suggests peer discussion helps learners notice errors.' These three steps take about thirty seconds, and they are the difference between a visual the audience glances at and a visual they understand.

[ ] Each visual matches its purpose: bars for comparison, lines for change over time.

[ ] No visual has more than three to six bars or three lines.

[ ] Gridlines, borders and extra series have been removed.

[ ] Labels are large and values are written on the visual itself.

[ ] Colour means something, and the visual works in black and white too.

[ ] I can explain each visual in three steps: what it shows, the key comparison, what it means.

Chapter 6: Speaking and Delivery - Pace, Voice, Body Language

A presentation is spoken, not written, and the way you speak matters as much as what you say. Research on audiences is consistent on this point: listeners judge a talk first by whether they can hear it, follow it and stay awake through it, and only then by the quality of the research. A brilliant study delivered in a mumble, at high speed, while reading from notes, will be remembered as a poor talk. A modest study delivered clearly, at a steady pace, with the speaker looking at the audience, will be remembered as a good one. Delivery is not a talent you are born with. It is a set of habits, and habits can be practised.

This chapter covers the three parts of delivery: pace, voice and body language. It also covers nerves, because almost every speaker is nervous, including experienced ones, and nerves need managing, not eliminating. The aim is not to make you a performer.

It is to make you a speaker the audience can hear, follow and trust.

6.1 Pace: slower than you think

Most nervous speakers speak too fast. They rush because they want the talk to be over, because they have too much material, or because silence feels awkward. The audience, meanwhile, needs time to hear a sentence, understand it, and connect it with the slide. A good pace for a presentation is slower than everyday conversation: about 120 to 140 words per minute, with pauses between ideas. If you are unsure of your pace, record yourself and count. If you finish a twenty-minute talk in twelve minutes, you spoke too fast and left no time for the audience to think.

6.2 Voice: clear, varied and loud enough

Speak loudly enough that the person in the back row can hear you without straining. If there is a microphone, use it, and test it before the talk: speak into it at your normal volume and ask someone at the back whether they can hear you. Do not hold a handheld microphone too close to your mouth, or it will distort your voice; hold it a hand's width away. If there is no microphone, project your voice to the back wall, not to the front row. Breathing helps: take a slow breath before you begin, and breathe from the stomach rather than the chest, which keeps the voice steady.

6.3 Body language: stand, look, gesture

Worked Example: A speaker who learned to slow down

A postgraduate student rehearsed her first talk and timed it at eleven minutes for a twenty-minute slot. She was speaking at nearly 180 words per minute. Her supervisor asked her to mark three pause points on her notes: after the question, after the main finding, and before the conclusion, each pause lasting a slow count of three. She also cut two slides. In the next rehearsal she took eighteen minutes, the audience in the practice room understood the finding, and she said afterwards that the pauses felt strange but the talk felt calm. On the day, she finished on time and answered four questions.

[ ] I speak at about 120 to 140 words per minute, with pauses after key points.

[ ] I can be heard from the back row, with or without a microphone.

[ ] I vary my pitch and pace instead of speaking in a flat voice.

[ ] I stand still, look at the audience, and gesture calmly.

[ ] My notes are brief prompts, not a full script.

[ ] I have a plan for nerves: preparation, early arrival, and a slow first minute.

Chapter 7: Handling Questions from the Audience

For many students, the question session is the most frightening part of a presentation. The talk itself can be rehearsed, but the questions cannot, and the fear is of being asked something you cannot answer, in front of an audience. That fear is understandable, but it is based on a misunderstanding of what questions are for. Questions are not an examination. They are the audience's way of engaging with your work: they ask because they are interested, because something was unclear, or because they see a connection you did not. A speaker who welcomes questions, listens carefully, and answers honestly is respected, even when the answer is 'I do not know.'

This chapter explains how to prepare for questions, how to listen and answer clearly, how to handle difficult and critical questions, and what to say when you genuinely do not know the answer. The skills are the same as the skills of the talk itself: clarity, honesty, and respect for the audience. A good question session can be the best part of a presentation, because it is where the speaker stops presenting and starts discussing research with colleagues.

7.1 Preparing for questions before the talk

Although you cannot predict every question, you can predict most of them. Before the talk, ask yourself the questions a careful listener would ask. Why did you choose this method rather than another? What are the limitations of your study? How would your findings change with a larger sample, a longer study, or a different setting? What would you do differently if you started again? What should future research investigate? Prepare a short answer to each of these, and have the evidence for it ready. If your study has a weak point, think about it before the talk, not during it, so that you can answer calmly when it is raised.

7.2 Listening and answering clearly

When a question is asked, listen to the whole question before you answer. Do not interrupt, do not start answering halfway through, and do not assume you know what the question will be. If the question is long or unclear, repeat it back in your own words: 'If I understand you correctly, you are asking whether the results would hold for younger learners. Is that right?' This gives you time to think, checks that you understood the question, and makes sure the whole audience heard it, including those at the back who may not have heard the questioner.

7.3 Difficult questions and disagreement

Some questions are critical: a listener disagrees with your method, doubts your interpretation, or points to a study that contradicts your findings. Do not become defensive. A critical question is usually a sign that the listener is taking your work seriously, and the audience respects a speaker who responds calmly. Listen, acknowledge the point, and answer on the evidence. Useful phrases are: 'That is a fair point. The reason I chose this method was...' and 'You are right that this study

does not cover that case. What it does show is...' These phrases acknowledge the criticism without surrendering your argument, and they keep the discussion on the evidence rather than on personalities.

7.4 When you do not know the answer

Every speaker is asked a question they cannot answer. The worst response is to invent an answer, because the audience will usually notice, and an invented answer damages trust in the whole talk. The best response is honest and short: 'I do not know the answer to that, but I can find out and let you know,' or 'That is beyond the scope of this study, and it would be a good question for future research.' Both answers are respectable. The first promises a follow-up, which you should then deliver if you gave contact details. The second turns a gap into a suggestion for future work, which is exactly what research is for.

Worked Example: An honest answer that won respect

At a student conference, a speaker was asked whether her findings would hold for learners in rural schools, which her study had not covered. She said: 'I do not know, because my study was in four city schools. I would expect the effect to be smaller where teachers have less training in peer feedback, but that is a guess, and it needs to be tested. It is the first study I would like to do next.' The questioner nodded, the audience moved on, and afterwards two people asked her about collaborating on that next study. Her honest answer had opened a door that a confident invention would have closed.

[ ] I have prepared short answers to the most likely questions.

[ ] I have one or two backup slides for detailed questions.

[ ] I listen to the whole question and repeat it back before answering.

[ ] My answers are short: direct answer first, then the reason.

[ ] I can say 'I do not know' honestly and offer a follow-up.

[ ] I stay calm under criticism and answer on the evidence.

Chapter 8: Poster Presentations

A poster presentation is a different skill from a spoken talk, and it suits many students well. Instead of speaking to a room for twenty minutes, you stand beside a large printed poster while visitors come to you, look at your work, and ask questions one at a time. It is less frightening than a talk, because the audience is small and the conversation is informal. It is also, in some ways, harder: the poster must explain your research without you, and you must be ready to explain it in one minute, in five minutes, or in a longer discussion, depending on who stops and how much time they have.

This chapter explains how to design a poster that can be read from a distance, how to organise its sections, and how to present it in person. The same principles apply as for slides — few words, large text, one visual per finding — but the poster has its own demands, because it must work both as a document on a wall and as the starting

point for a conversation.

8.1 Designing the poster

A standard poster is large, usually about one metre wide and a little less tall, and it is read from one or two metres away. That means the text must be large: the title should be readable from three metres, headings from two metres, and body text from one metre. In practice, the title should be at least 72 points, headings at least 36 points, and body text at least 24 points. If you cannot fit your words at those sizes, you have too many words. A poster is not a paper pasted on a wall. It is a summary, and most posters have between 300 and 800 words in total.

8.2 What to put on the poster, and what to leave out

Include the title, the names of the authors and their institution, the research question, a brief method, the main findings with one or two visuals, the conclusion, and contact details. Include a small number of references, if the conference requires them, in small text at the bottom. Leave out the literature review, the full procedure, the raw data, and any table with more than a few numbers. Those belong in the paper or in a handout. A visitor should be able to understand the poster in two minutes without you, and in thirty seconds they should be able to tell what the study found.

8.3 Presenting beside your poster

Standing beside a poster is a conversation, not a speech. Prepare three versions of your explanation. The one-minute version is for a visitor in a hurry: the problem, the question, the main finding, and the conclusion, in four sentences. The five-minute version adds the method and a second finding, and points to the visuals as you speak. The longer version is a discussion: you answer the visitor's questions, show them the details, and ask what they think. Start by greeting the visitor and asking what interests them, rather than launching into a speech. A simple 'Hello, would you like a quick tour of the poster?' works well.

Version	Length	What to include
One-minute tour	1 minute	Problem, question, main finding, conclusion
Five-minute tour	5 minutes	Method, two findings, visuals, conclusion
Discussion	As long as needed	Details, questions, ideas, future work

[ ] The poster has 300 to 800 words and can be read from two metres away.

[ ] The title is large, the sections read left to right, and the main visual is central.

[ ] The poster includes question, method, findings, conclusion and contact details.

[ ] I have printed it early, checked it at full size, and proofread it.

[ ] I have a one-minute and a five-minute version of my explanation ready.

[ ] I have handouts, pins, and a pen for taking notes.

Chapter 9: Online and Virtual Presentations

Online presentations have become a normal part of academic life. A virtual conference, a departmental seminar on video, or a recorded talk may be your first experience of presenting, and it has its own rules. The audience is not in the room with you. They may be in different time zones, watching on small screens, with distractions around them. The speaker cannot read the room, cannot see most faces, and cannot rely on the energy of a live audience. The talk must therefore be clearer, slower and more visual than a live talk, and the technology must be tested in advance, because a technical failure in the first minute can lose the audience for the whole session.

This chapter covers the practical side of presenting online: setting up your space and equipment, sharing slides, speaking to a camera, managing questions in a chat, and recording a talk. The principles of structure, audience and slide design from earlier chapters still apply. What changes is how you deliver them through a screen.

9.1 Setting up your space and equipment

Choose a quiet room with a plain background and good light on your face. Sit facing a window or a lamp, not with a bright window behind you, which will turn you into a silhouette. Place the camera at eye level, not below your chin, and sit close enough that your head and shoulders fill a good part of the frame. Test your microphone and your internet connection before the session. A wired connection is more stable than wireless if you can use one. Close other applications, silence notifications, and keep a glass of water nearby. Tell the people around you that you will be presenting and should not be disturbed.

9.2 Sharing slides and speaking to a camera

Share your slides before you start speaking, and check that the audience can see them. Share the presentation window itself, not your whole screen, so that the audience does not see your notifications or other files. Use the presenter's view if your software offers it, so that you can see your notes and the next slide while the audience sees only the slide. Advance the slides yourself, and pause after each important slide, because online audiences need a moment longer to absorb a visual than a live audience does.

9.3 Questions, chat and recordings

[ ] My room is quiet, well lit, and has a plain background.

[ ] The camera is at eye level and the microphone has been tested.

[ ] I share only the presentation window, not my whole screen.

[ ] I speak to the camera, slowly and clearly, with extra pauses.

[ ] I have agreed with the chair how questions and chat will be handled.

[ ] I have a backup plan if the connection fails: a phone hotspot or a recorded talk.

Chapter 10: Timing and Rehearsal

Timing is the part of presenting that most often goes wrong, and it goes wrong for a simple reason: speakers do not rehearse with a timer. They prepare slides, they read through their notes, and they assume the talk will take the time they have been given. On the day, they speak more slowly than they expected, or they add explanations they had not planned, or they spend too long on the background, and they run out of time before the findings. The chair interrupts them, the conclusion is rushed, and there is no time for questions. Rehearsal prevents this. It is the least glamorous part of presenting and the most important.

This chapter explains how to plan the timing of a talk, how to rehearse it properly, and what to do when the timing goes wrong on the day. The rule is simple: a talk that has been rehearsed aloud, standing up, with a timer, will run on time. A talk that has only been read silently will not.

10.1 Planning the time

Divide your time before you write your notes. For a twenty-minute talk, a useful division is: two minutes for the problem, two minutes for the question and the gap, three minutes for the method, eight minutes for the findings, three minutes for the contribution and conclusion, and two minutes in reserve. For a fifteen-minute talk, keep the same proportions and cut the findings to five or six minutes, with fewer findings. For a ten-minute talk, present one finding only, and give it the time it deserves. Whatever the length, protect the conclusion: a talk that ends without a conclusion has no message, however good the middle was.

Part of the talk	20-minute talk	15-minute talk	10-minute talk
Problem and question	4 minutes	3 minutes	2 minutes
Method	3 minutes	2 minutes	1 minute
Findings	8 minutes	6 minutes	4 minutes
Contribution and close	3 minutes	2 minutes	2 minutes
Reserve	2 minutes	2 minutes	1 minute

10.2 Rehearsing aloud, standing up

10.3 When the timing goes wrong on the day

Even a well-rehearsed talk can run long on the day, because the audience laughs, a question interrupts, or a slide takes longer to explain than expected. Have a plan for this. Mark two or three slides in your notes as slides you can skip if you are behind time: a secondary finding, an extra example, a detail of the method. If you reach the halfway point and you are behind, skip one of them without apology and without telling the audience. The audience will not know what you skipped. They will know if you rush the conclusion.

Worked Example: A rehearsal that saved a talk

A student prepared a twenty-minute talk with twenty-eight slides. In his first timed rehearsal he took twenty-six minutes and had not reached the conclusion. He cut eight slides, combined two findings onto one visual, and marked two more slides as skippable. In his second rehearsal he took nineteen minutes. On the day, a question from the chair took a minute, he skipped one marked slide, and he finished in twenty minutes with time for four questions. The rehearsal had not made his research better. It had made his talk possible.

[ ] I have divided my time by section and protected the conclusion.

[ ] I have no more slides than minutes, and fewer is better.

[ ] I have rehearsed aloud, standing up, with a timer, at least three times.

[ ] I have rehearsed in front of at least one other person.

[ ] Two or three slides are marked as skippable if I run behind time.

[ ] I know what I will do if I finish early: slow down and welcome questions.

Chapter 11: Common Mistakes and a Checklist

The mistakes in this chapter appear in presentation after presentation, in every subject and at every level. They are not mistakes of intelligence or of research quality. They are mistakes of preparation, and every one of them is avoidable. Read this chapter a week before your talk, when there is still time to fix what it finds, and read it again on the morning of the talk as a final check. A speaker who avoids these mistakes will already be better than most presenters in the room.

11.1 The ten most common mistakes

- Trying to present the whole thesis instead of one clear message.
- Slides full of paragraphs in small text, read aloud to the audience.
- Starting with a long history of the field instead of the problem.
- Spending too long on background and method, and rushing the findings.
- Showing tables and graphs the audience cannot read in seconds.
- Speaking too fast, too quietly, or in a flat voice with no pauses.
- Reading from a script or from notes instead of speaking to the audience.
- Running over time and leaving no time for questions.

- Apologising for being a student, for the slides, or for the research.
- Inventing an answer to a question instead of saying honestly that you do not know.

11.2 Mistakes of attitude

11.3 The final checklist

Work through this checklist the day before your talk, with your slides open and your notes in hand. Tick each item only when you have checked it in practice, not from memory. If an item is not ticked, fix it now, while there is still time.

[ ] My one-message sentence is written down and I can say it aloud.

[ ] My slides have few words, large text, and one visual per finding.

[ ] Every visual can be read in seconds from the back of the room.

[ ] My talk follows problem, question, method, findings, contribution.

[ ] I have rehearsed aloud, standing up, with a timer, at least three times.

[ ] I finish on time in rehearsal, with time left for questions.

[ ] I have prepared answers to the most likely questions.

[ ] I have backup slides for detailed questions.

[ ] I have checked the equipment, the room, and my notes.

[ ] I know the name of the chair and how questions will be handled.

[ ] I have water, a watch or timer, and a copy of my slides.

[ ] I will not apologise for being a student; I will present my work with confidence.

Chapter 12: Worked Example - A Complete Fictional Talk Outline

This chapter gives a complete outline for a twenty-minute conference talk. The study is entirely fictional: the researcher, the schools, the numbers and the findings are invented to show how a talk is structured. No real person, school or study is described. Adapt the outline to your own research by replacing the fictional details with your own problem, question, method and findings, keeping the structure, the timing and the slide titles. The outline shows what a finished talk looks like when the advice in this guide is applied.

12.1 The fictional study

The fictional study asks whether structured peer feedback improves writing accuracy. The researcher worked in four public secondary schools over six weeks, with 120 intermediate learners divided into three groups: peer feedback, teacher feedback, and a control group that received no structured feedback. Accuracy was measured by a writing test before and after the six weeks, and by a follow-up test four weeks later. The main finding was that the peer-feedback group improved most, and the improvement lasted. The outline below turns that study into a talk.

Slide	Title (written as a conclusion)	Time
1	Title: Does Peer Feedback Improve Writing Accuracy?	0:00
2	Many students write every week but improve slowly	0:30
3	Question: does peer feedback work better than teacher feedback?	2:00
4	What was known, and what was missing	3:00
5	Method: three groups, six weeks, four schools	4:00
6	Accuracy improved in all groups	7:00
7	Peer feedback gained most	9:00
8	The gain lasted four weeks later	11:00
9	Why peer discussion may help learners notice errors	13:00
10	What this means for teachers and for future research	15:00
11	Conclusion: peer feedback works, and it lasts	17:00
12	Thank you - questions welcome (with contact details)	18:00

12.2 What the speaker says for each slide

Slide 1 is the title slide, shown while the speaker is introduced. It carries the title, the speaker's name and institution, and the name of the conference. The speaker does not read it aloud. Slide 2 opens the talk with a concrete problem: a classroom where students write every week but their accuracy improves slowly. The speaker describes that classroom in two sentences, then states the problem. Slide 3 shows the research question on its own, in large text. The speaker reads it aloud, slowly, and pauses, so

that the audience can absorb it.

Slide 4 states what was already known in two short points and names the gap in one sentence: earlier work showed that learners value feedback, but none had measured whether peer feedback improved accuracy in a public-school classroom. Slide 5 explains the method in three points: three groups, six weeks, four schools, with the numbers on the slide and the detail in the speaker's words. The speaker names the limit here: the study ran for six weeks in one city, so the findings describe short-term change in that setting.

Slides 6, 7 and 8 present the findings, one per slide. Slide 6 shows a bar chart with three bars and the title 'Accuracy improved in all groups'. The speaker says what the chart shows, points to the bars, and moves on. Slide 7 shows the same chart with the peer-feedback bar highlighted and the title 'Peer feedback gained most'. The speaker gives the key comparison and its meaning. Slide 8 shows a line chart of the follow-up test with the title 'The gain lasted four weeks later'. The speaker pauses after this slide, because it is the strongest finding, and lets it land before continuing.

Worked Example: The opening minute, word for word

Fictional script. 'Good morning. I want to start in a classroom. Every week, the students in this classroom write an essay. Every week, the teacher marks it. And every week, the same errors appear again. The students are working hard, the teacher is working hard, and yet accuracy improves very slowly. My question is simple: would the students improve faster if they gave feedback to each other, in a structured way, instead of waiting for the teacher? That is the question I studied, and today I will tell you what I found.' In under a minute, the audience knows the problem, the question, and what the talk will do.

12.3 Questions the speaker prepared for

[ ] My talk has a title slide, a problem slide, a question slide, and a conclusion slide.

[ ] Each finding has its own slide with a title written as a conclusion.

[ ] I have written what I will say for each slide, in brief prompts.

[ ] I have prepared short answers to at least five likely questions.

[ ] My timing adds up to the time I have been given, with two minutes in reserve.

Chapter 13: Conclusion

A research presentation is a skill, not a talent. It can be learned, practised and improved, and every talk you give will make the next one easier. The students who present well are rarely the most confident people in the room. They are the most prepared: they know their one message, they know their audience, they have structured their talk around problem, question, method, findings and contribution, they have designed slides that support rather than replace them, and they have rehearsed aloud with a timer until the talk runs on time.

If you take one idea from this guide, let it be this: respect the audience's time and

intelligence. Say one clear thing well, show the evidence for it, name the limits honestly, and invite the audience to respond. Do that, and your research will be heard, remembered and discussed — which is the purpose of presenting it at all. Your first talk will not be perfect, and it does not need to be. It needs to be clear, honest and on time. The second one will be better. Start with the one-message sentence, build the talk around it, rehearse it aloud, and then go and present your work with confidence. Good luck — and enjoy the questions.

Suggested Reading

The following are general, well-known types of works that students commonly consult when learning to present research. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on academic speaking and presentation.

- Standard guides to academic writing and presentation: widely used guides explain how to structure a talk, design slides and handle questions, with examples from many subjects.
- Guides to public speaking and communication: general works on speaking clearly, managing nerves and engaging an audience are useful for academic presenters as well as for other speakers.
- Books on data visualisation: standard works on presenting data clearly explain how to choose and simplify charts, tables and diagrams for an audience.
- The official manual of your referencing style: the authoritative source for citation and formatting rules — consult the edition your department requires.
- Your university's guidance on conferences and presentations, and your supervisor's recommended reading for your subject: the most relevant sources, because they are chosen for your specific context and field.